

FREE RESOURCE · WEB DEVELOPMENT

Software Development Glossary

A 60-term glossary of software development terms for non-technical project managers and business stakeholders — plain language definitions with practical context examples.

60 Terms

Plain Language

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Quick Reference

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categories

Plain

language

Real

examples

HOW TO USE THIS GLOSSARY

Terms are grouped by category rather than strict alphabetical order, so related concepts sit near each other — useful if you're trying to understand an area, not just look up a single word. Each entry includes a plain-language definition and a practical example of how the term shows up in a real project conversation.

General Development Concepts

20 terms

API

A defined way for two pieces of software to talk to each other — like a menu of requests one system can make of another.

Example: Your booking site uses a payment provider's API to process card payments without building payment processing from scratch.

Backend

The part of an application that runs on the server, handling data, logic, and security — invisible to the end user.

Example: When a customer submits an order, the backend checks stock levels and records the sale.

Frontend

The part of an application the user actually sees and interacts with — buttons, forms, layouts.

Example: A slow-loading frontend can make a fast, well-built backend feel broken to users.

Full Stack

Describes a developer or system that works across both frontend and backend.

Example: A full stack developer can build the login screen and the database logic behind it.

Framework

A pre-built structure of code that developers build on top of, rather than starting from nothing.

Example: Using a framework can cut weeks off a project timeline compared to building every piece from scratch.

Library

A reusable package of code that performs a specific job, which developers plug into their own project.

Example: A date-formatting library saves the team from writing that logic themselves.

Repository

The storage location — usually in a tool like GitHub — where a project's code and its full history live.

Example: Ask for read access to the repository if you want to see how the project's code has evolved.

Deployment

The process of moving new code from development into the live, working product.

Example: A deployment scheduled for Friday afternoon is generally considered risky practice.

Environment (Dev / Staging / Production)

Separate copies of the application used for building, testing, and running the real thing, so changes can be tested safely.

Example: A bug found in staging is caught before it ever reaches production, where real customers are.

Legacy Code

Older code, often undocumented or hard to change, that a team maintains rather than replaces.

Example: Legacy code is often why a seemingly small feature request takes far longer than expected.

Technical Debt

Shortcuts taken to ship faster now, which cost extra time and risk to fix properly later.

Example: The team flagged technical debt in the checkout flow that will need addressing before the next major feature.

Refactoring

Rewriting existing code to be cleaner or more maintainable, without changing what it does for the user.

Example: Refactoring rarely shows up as a visible feature, but it reduces the risk of future bugs.

Bug

An error in the software that causes it to behave incorrectly or unexpectedly.

Example: The reported bug meant discount codes weren't applying at checkout.

Patch

A small update released to fix a specific bug or security issue.

Example: A security patch was released within 24 hours of the vulnerability being discovered.

Release

A version of the software made available to users, bundling a set of changes together.

Example: The next release includes the redesigned dashboard the team demoed last month.

Version Control

A system that tracks every change made to code over time, so teams can collaborate and undo mistakes safely.

Example: Version control let the team roll back instantly when a change broke the login page.

Codebase

The complete collection of source code that makes up an application.

Example: A large, sprawling codebase generally takes new developers longer to become productive in.

Open Source

Software whose code is publicly available for anyone to view, use, or contribute to.

Example: The project uses several open source libraries instead of building that functionality internally.

SDK (Software Development Kit)

A bundle of tools, code, and documentation that helps developers build for a specific platform.

Example: Building the mobile app required the platform's official SDK.

Middleware

Software that sits between two systems, handling communication or processing in between.

Example: Middleware checks that a user is logged in before letting a request reach the backend.

Web & Application Concepts

13 terms

Frontend Framework

A structured toolkit (such as React, Vue, or Angular) used to build the visible, interactive part of an application.

Example: Switching frontend frameworks mid-project is a significant undertaking, not a quick swap.

Responsive Design

An approach ensuring a site or app displays and works well across phones, tablets, and desktops.

Example: Responsive design is why the same website looks right whether it's opened on a phone or a laptop.

UI (User Interface)

The visual elements a user interacts with — buttons, menus, screens, colours, layout.

Example: A cluttered UI can make even a powerful feature feel confusing to use.

UX (User Experience)

The overall experience and ease someone has using a product, beyond just how it looks.

Example: Good UX means a new user can complete a task without needing instructions.

Wireframe

A simple, low-detail sketch of a screen's layout, used to plan structure before visual design.

Example: *The wireframe showed where the search bar and filters would sit before any colours or branding were applied.*

Prototype

An interactive, early version of a product used to test ideas before full development begins.

Example: *Testing the prototype with five real users surfaced a confusing checkout step early, before it was built.*

CMS (Content Management System)

A tool that lets non-technical users add, edit, and publish content without touching code.

Example: *The marketing team updates blog posts directly through the CMS.*

SaaS (Software as a Service)

Software hosted by a provider and accessed online, typically via subscription, rather than installed locally.

Example: *The company's project management tool is a SaaS product billed monthly per user.*

Cloud Computing

Running software and storing data on remote servers accessed over the internet, rather than on local machines.

Example: *Moving to cloud computing let the team scale up capacity during a busy sales period without buying new hardware.*

Hosting

The service that makes a website or application accessible on the internet.

Example: *A hosting outage is why the website was briefly unreachable last Tuesday.*

Domain

The web address people type to reach a site, such as mddbusinessconsulting.com.

Example: *The domain needs renewing annually or the website can become unreachable.*

SSL Certificate

A security credential that encrypts data between a website and its visitors, shown by the padlock in a browser.

Example: *An expired SSL certificate is often why a browser suddenly warns that a site isn't secure.*

CDN (Content Delivery Network)

A network of servers around the world that deliver a website's content from the location nearest the visitor.

Example: *A CDN is why the same website loads quickly for users in different countries.*

Data & Databases

[8 terms](#)

Database

An organised system for storing and retrieving data, such as customer records or orders.

Example: *Every order placed on the site gets written to the database.*

SQL

A standard language used to query and manage data held in traditional, structured databases.

Example: *The analytics team wrote a SQL query to pull last quarter's sales by region.*

NoSQL

A category of databases built for flexible, less rigidly structured data, often used at large scale.

Example: *The product catalogue uses a NoSQL database because product attributes vary widely by category.*

Schema

The defined structure of a database — what tables, fields, and relationships exist.

Example: *Changing the schema partway through a project can require significant rework elsewhere.*

API Endpoint

A specific address within an API that performs one particular action or returns one type of data.

Example: *The "get customer details" endpoint is called every time the account page loads.*

Data Migration

The process of moving data from one system or format to another.

Example: *The data migration from the old CRM took three weeks and required careful validation.*

Backup

A saved copy of data kept separately so it can be restored if the original is lost or corrupted.

Example: *A recent backup meant the team lost only an hour of data after the server failure.*

Cache / Caching

Temporarily storing frequently used data closer at hand so it loads faster next time.

Example: *Caching is why a page loads instantly on a second visit but slower the first time.*

DevOps & Infrastructure

8 terms

CI/CD

Continuous Integration / Continuous Deployment — automated processes that test and release code changes frequently and reliably.

Example: *CI/CD is why the team can release small updates several times a week instead of one large release per quarter.*

DevOps

A way of working that brings development and operations teams together to release software faster and more reliably.

Example: *Adopting DevOps practices cut the company's average deployment time from days to hours.*

Server

A computer (physical or virtual) that runs software and serves it to users over a network.

Example: *When people say "the server is down," they mean the machine hosting the application has stopped responding.*

Load Balancing

Distributing incoming traffic across multiple servers so no single one gets overwhelmed.

Example: *Load balancing kept the site responsive during a traffic spike from a marketing campaign.*

Uptime

The percentage of time a system is available and working, often quoted as a service guarantee.

Example: *A 99.9% uptime guarantee still allows for roughly 8-9 hours of downtime per year.*

Scalability

A system's ability to handle growth — more users, more data, more traffic — without breaking down.

Example: *The platform's scalability was tested deliberately before the holiday sales rush.*

Container (Docker)

A lightweight, self-contained package that bundles an application with everything it needs to run consistently anywhere.

Example: *Using containers meant the app behaved identically on a developer's laptop and on the live server.*

Microservices

An architecture where an application is split into small, independent services rather than one large connected system.

Example: *Microservices let the payments team deploy updates without waiting on the inventory team's release schedule.*

Agile & Project Terms

7 terms

Sprint

A fixed, short time period (commonly two weeks) in which a development team commits to completing a set amount of work.

Example: *The login redesign was planned across two sprints.*

Backlog

The full list of features, fixes, and tasks a team could work on, prioritised but not yet scheduled.

Example: *That feature request has been added to the backlog for consideration in a future sprint.*

User Story

A short description of a feature written from the user's perspective, explaining what they need and why.

Example: *"As a returning customer, I want my details saved so I can check out faster" is a typical user story.*

Standup / Daily Scrum

A short daily meeting where the team shares progress, plans, and blockers.

Example: *The standup surfaced a blocker early, saving two days of a developer waiting on someone else's answer.*

Velocity

A measure of how much work a team typically completes per sprint, used to forecast future timelines.

Example: *Based on current velocity, the team estimated the feature would take three more sprints.*

MVP (Minimum Viable Product)

The smallest usable version of a product that delivers real value, built to test an idea before investing further.

Example: *The MVP launched with just one payment method to validate demand before adding more.*

Kanban

A visual way of managing work as cards moving through columns such as To Do, In Progress, and Done.

Example: *The support team uses a Kanban board to track incoming bug reports.*

Testing & Quality

4 terms

QA (Quality Assurance)

The practice and team responsible for finding defects and confirming software works as intended before release.

Example: QA caught the checkout bug two days before the planned release.

Unit Test

An automated test that checks one small, specific piece of code works correctly in isolation.

Example: A unit test confirms the discount calculation returns the right amount for a given code.

Regression Testing

Re-testing existing features after a change, to confirm nothing that used to work has broken.

Example: Regression testing caught that the new search feature had accidentally broken the filters.

UAT (User Acceptance Testing)

Testing done by actual business users or stakeholders to confirm the software meets real-world needs before go-live.

Example: The finance team ran UAT on the new reporting tool before it replaced the old system.

WHEN IN DOUBT, ASK

No glossary fully replaces asking your development team to explain a term in the context of your specific project — the same word can carry slightly different meaning depending on the system involved. Use this guide to follow the conversation, then ask a direct follow-up question when something still isn't clear.